Pioneers of Social Research: Interview Guide

Pre-interview
Look for an outline biography of cv of the person you are recording (Wikipedia, Who's Who, or they may send you a cv)

Try to give a hard look at what seem to be the researcher's key books

For every interview it is essential to establish in the early part
a) the date and place of birth of the interviewee, their family background and occupations;
b) what led them towards research and university work;
c) what were they key influences in leading them towards their pioneering research themes.
d)

Opening questions

Date of birth, family and own occupations.

Can we begin by talking about your family background and early life, and any early influences which may have led you towards university work?

FAMILY AND EARLY LIFE

- Memories of ***family background*** and ***grandparents:*** were they an influence?
- ***Parents*** **-** where they came from, their jobs, their characters, could you talk to them, were you close to them;
- ***Education*** **-** school and ***University***: important friendships and influences
- ***Youth*** **-** important friends and their influences; what you did in ***National Service***

PIONEERING RESEARCH

- ***Main research interest*** **-** how you got into it, describe what it was:

Go through the sequence of main projects and books
With each, ask what was the objective, what were the difficulties
When there was fieldwork, ask for a detailed account of how it went: types of contacts (insider or (colonial) outsider? especially for work overseas), types of samples and interview, participant observation etc.
What documents were kept (and could be archived)
Sometimes I think in this section you can risk debating a little, to clarify the researcher's position
What would you say is the key contribution which you have made?

WORKING CAREER

* ***First job*** **-** why you chose it
- Other early jobs and then ***main jobs*** - why and how; did you plan a ***career,*** or find it by chance

* Describe your work role;
- Do you remember some of the people you worked with - important influences at work, friends and enemies - can you tell us something about them?
- ***Social life*** connected with work.

LATER FAMILY LIFE AND LEISURE

- Whether single or married; if married, how you met your ***husband or wife,*** their background, jobs;

- ***Children*** - ideals of parenting, hopes and ambitions for children
* ***Leisure and hobbies*** – what have been your main enthusiasms outside work
- ***Friends*** how important have friends been to you? Have any been special influences?
- ***Later life*** - how do you see your focus in or approaching retirement: continuing research and writing, or new activities, becoming grandparents?

Closing questions for all interviews

Looking back on your working career, in your work, what you are most proud of?
Summing up your life as a whole, what have been the worst and the best things?